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AFP

WORLD CUP'S SMALLEST NATION TAKES THE FIELD

■ Curaçao supporters cheer ahead of their country's World Cup Group E match against Germany at the Houston Stadium yesterday. Curaçao, a Caribbean island of 160,000 people — the smallest nation by population in the tournament — is making its World Cup debut, a beneficiary of FIFA's decision to expand the field to 48 teams this year. **SEE ALSO P12-13, 15**

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UAE creates Federal Authority for Artificial Intelligence and Data

Omar Al Olama
tasked with
leading the federal
technology body

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

The UAE has established a new federal authority to oversee artificial intelligence, data governance and digital government, in a move designed to consolidate the country's technology agenda under a single national framework.

His Highness Sheikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, announced the establishment of the Federal Authority for Artificial Intelligence and Data, as the unified national umbrella for managing data, artificial intelligence

and digital government across the country.

The new authority will report directly to the UAE Cabinet and will be led by Omar Sultan Al Olama, Minister of State for Artificial Intelligence, Digital Economy and Remote Work Applications.

More efficient

In a post on X, Sheikh Mohammed said the authority's objective is to build a government that is "more efficient, flexible and proactive", while accelerating the use of advanced technologies to improve public services and support future generations.

"We are continuing to develop the government of the future," Sheikh Mohammed said, adding that data and AI-powered tools would enable faster decision-making, stronger government performance and improved services for citizens and residents.

The authority brings together the responsibilities of the UAE's Artificial Intelligence Office, the Information and Digital Government Sector within the Telecommunications and Digital Government Regulatory Authority, and the Emirates Data Office.

The Authority's functions include unifying national directions and priorities that support a unified digital government system using Agentic AI, proposing national public policies, legislation and strategies, and ensuring alignment and integration between digital initiatives and projects at the federal and local levels.

The Artificial Intelligence and Data Authority will develop and lead the national AI strategy, work to increase the digital economy's contribution to the country's GDP, and manage government data to ensure its quality, availability and sharing across federal entities.

Sharjah Police save woman making 'Pizza Order' call

Dispatcher decodes urgent call for help

DUBAI

BY AGHADDIR ALI
Senior Reporter

A coded "pizza delivery" request made to Sharjah Police's emergency line has led to the swift rescue of an expatriate woman who was unable to openly seek help while under threat at home, officials said.

Captain Majid Al Bas, Head of the Communications Operations Branch at Sharjah Police during Sharjah Police programme Aman Ya Biladi, said the incident unfolded when an emergency dispatcher at Sharjah Police received a call from a woman who insisted she wanted to "order a pizza," despite being informed she had reached the police

emergency centre. Sensing that the caller was speaking under duress, the duty officer, identified as Khamis, realised the unusual request was a disguised plea for help.

Swift action

While keeping the caller engaged on the line, Khamis alerted his supervisor and initiated tracing procedures. The operations centre was able to identify the woman's location within Sharjah, prompting immediate deployment of field units.

Police teams later found the woman being threatened by her husband, who was reportedly in an "abnormal state" at the time of the intervention. Officers secured the scene swiftly and ensured the woman's safety.

DON'T BLOW THE PEACE DEAL, TRUMP TELLS ISRAEL, IRAN

Strikes on Beirut prompt sharp Iranian pushback

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump yesterday urged restraint after Israel's military said it carried out strikes on Hezbollah targets in Beirut, in a move that could complicate efforts to finalise a US-Iran peace deal.

Iran threatened a military response. Trump reacted on social media: "We are very close to a deal that will bring peace to the region," and "Let's not blow it!"

Trump, who had said the deal could be signed yesterday, has pressed Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to stop hitting Lebanon hard while a deal is near, but the prime minister has defied him.

Netanyahu's office said the strikes were in response to Hezbollah attacks on northern Israel. Israel's military said Hezbollah launched three projectiles, releasing footage where an audible boom was followed by rising smoke.

No tolerance

"Israel will not tolerate firing into its territory," Netanyahu and Defence Minister Israel Katz said in a statement.

Iran's chief negotiator Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf sharply criticised the latest Israeli action, saying there was "no point" in continuing talks with the United States.

"The Zionists' aggression

UAE NOT AN ADVOCATE OF WAR: GARGASH

The UAE has never been an advocate of war and will continue to champion peace and stability, while remaining firmly committed to defending its sovereignty and national interests, Dr Anwar Gargash, Diplomatic Adviser to the UAE President, said as expectations grow over a potential agreement between Washington and Tehran.

In a post on X, Gargash said the anticipated accord could help close a chapter of regional tensions and open a political pathway that he hoped would prove successful. "As we approach the expected agreement between Washington and Tehran, which would turn the page on war and open a political track that we hope will succeed, we can only commend the way our wise leadership has handled this crisis and its repercussions," he wrote.

"We have never been advocates of war and will always remain advocates of peace and stability, while maintaining our firm commitment to defending the nation and safeguarding its sovereignty and interests," Gargash added.

—Gulf News Report

against Dahieh once again showed that the United States either lacks the will to implement its commitments or lacks the ability to do so," he said on X.

"If you do not have the will or the ability to fulfil your commitments, then there is no point in talking about continuing down this path," he added.

Iranian Brigadier General Mohammad Jafar Asadi warned that Israel's strikes "will not go unanswered".

The diplomatic push has sought to finalise a memorandum of understanding that would establish a 60-day ceasefire framework, reopen the Strait of Hormuz, and launch further negotiations on Iran's nuclear programme and US sanctions relief.

A delegation from Qatar arrived in Tehran yesterday to

help facilitate finalisation of the agreement, according to a diplomat familiar with the talks. Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif had earlier suggested the deal could be signed within 24 hours, while Iranian officials offered a more cautious timeline, saying no final decision had been taken.

Fars news agency, citing sources close to the negotiating team, said Tehran had still not approved the memorandum, reflecting internal divisions within Iran over the terms of the deal.

The proposed agreement has faced resistance from hardline Iranian lawmakers and military-linked media, who argue it would reduce Tehran's leverage over the strategic Strait of Hormuz.

— with inputs from AP
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